THE PIANO BUTLER · LEVEL BOOK

Beginner

Ten rooms: sitting and hands, the keyboard, fingering, the staff, the beat, notes and rests one at a time, loud and soft. Read each room, listen to it in the app, then practise.

THE ROOMS

1 · Posture and hand shape
2 · The keyboard
3 · Fingering
4 · The staff and the clefs
5 · Pulse, tempo and the bar
6 · Notes: the crotchet
7 · Notes: the minim
8 · Notes: three beats
9 · Notes: the semibreve
10 · Loud and soft

BEGINNER · ROOM 1

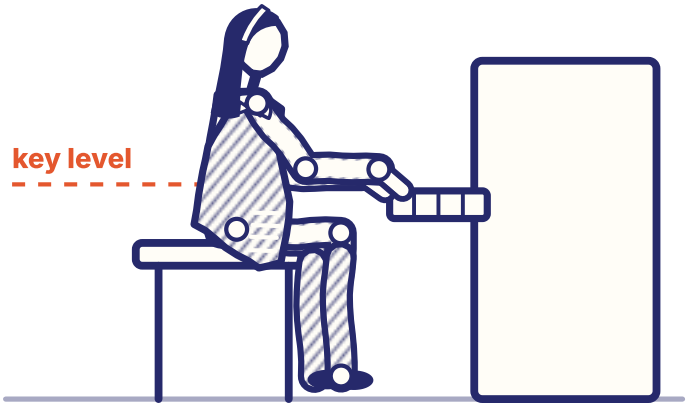
Posture and hand shape

More in the Handbook, pp. 18–20

SCAN TO LISTEN

THE SECRET

Sit tall, forearms level with the keys, a round hand on the fingertips: then let the arm's weight do the work.

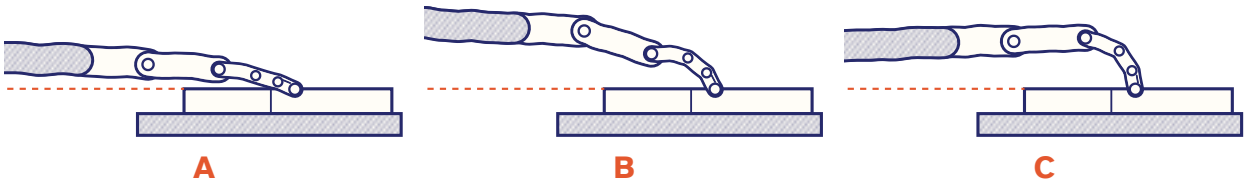


1. **forearms level with the keys**
   wrist neither dropped nor lifted
2. **elbows a little in front of you**
   not pinned to your sides
3. **sit on the front half of the stool**
   opposite Middle C
4. **feet flat on the floor**
   the right foot near the pedal
5. **back tall, shoulders loose**
   lean a little towards the keys

Tall back, level arms, flat feet

EXAMPLE 1

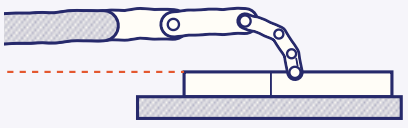
Which hand is round?



1. **Look at the knuckles:** up, or sunk in?
2. **Look at the tips:** does the finger stand on its tip?
3. **Which hand** could play all day?

C: knuckles up, curved fingers, standing on the tips. A is flat; B's knuckle has caved in.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



The ball test.

Hold a small ball or an orange, then put the hand on the keys without changing its shape. That is your playing hand.

BEGINNER · ROOM 1 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 Finger numbers

★☆☆

Write the number of each finger. They are the same in both hands. The first is done.

FINGER	NUMBER	FINGER	NUMBER
thumb	1	ring finger	
index finger		little finger	
middle finger			

2 Too low, too high, or right?

★★☆

Write too low, too high or right.

WHAT YOU SEE	THE STOOL IS
The elbows are well below the keys; the forearms go uphill.	too low
The forearms are level with the keys.	
The elbows are above the keys; the wrists drop down to them.	

3 The 30-second check

★☆☆

Every time you sit down to practise, check each line and tick a circle. One circle per day.

	MON TO SUN
Stool: forearms level with the keys	○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○
Body: front half of the stool, feet flat	○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○
Shoulders: lifted, then dropped	○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○
Hands: round, knuckles up	○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○
Breathe out, then play	○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

BEGINNER · ROOM 2

The keyboard

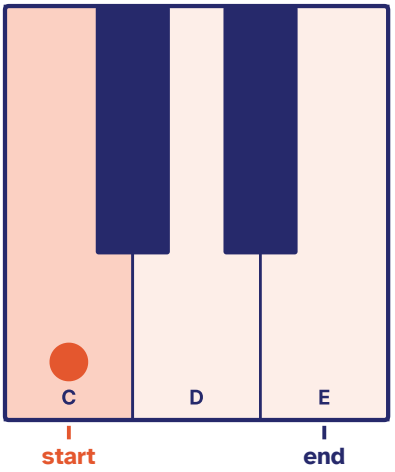
More in the Handbook, pp. 22–26

SCAN TO LISTEN

THE SECRET

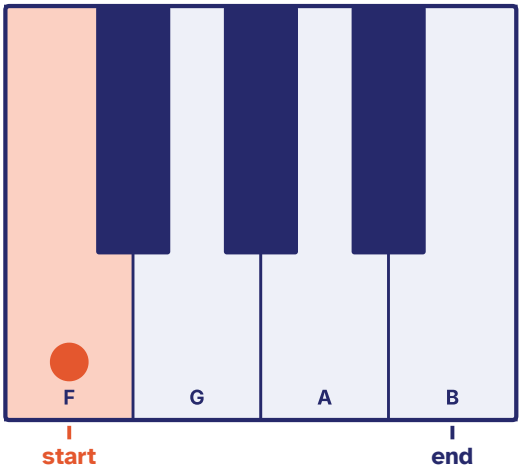
Two black keys: start on C. Three black keys: start on F. Then walk on.

2 black keys: C D E



on the piano E and F touch

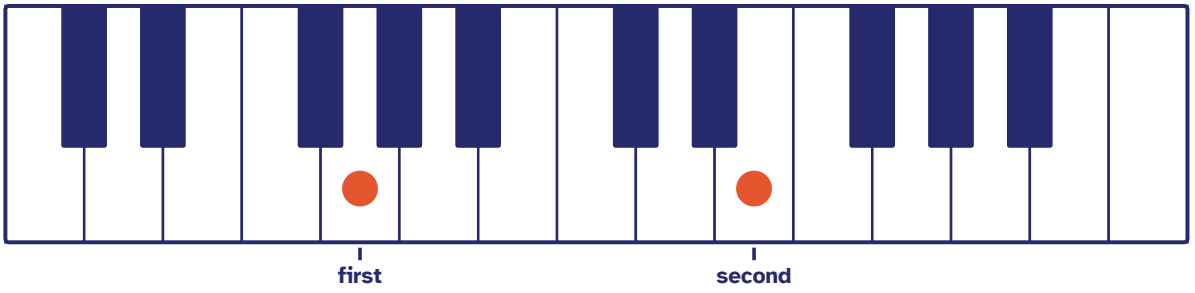
3 black keys: F G A B



Pulled apart: each family has a first key (start) and a last key (end)

EXAMPLE 1

Higher or lower?



1. **Find the two red keys.**
2. **Which one is further right?**
3. **Right means higher:** play both and listen.

The second note is **higher**: it is to the right. Left is always lower, right always higher.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

2 · 3

Find every group of two.

Start at the bottom of the piano. Touch each group of two black keys with fingers 2 and 3, all the way to the top. Then do the same with the groups of three.

BEGINNER · ROOM 2 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 Twos and threes

★☆☆

Circle every group of two black keys and every group of three. How many of each?

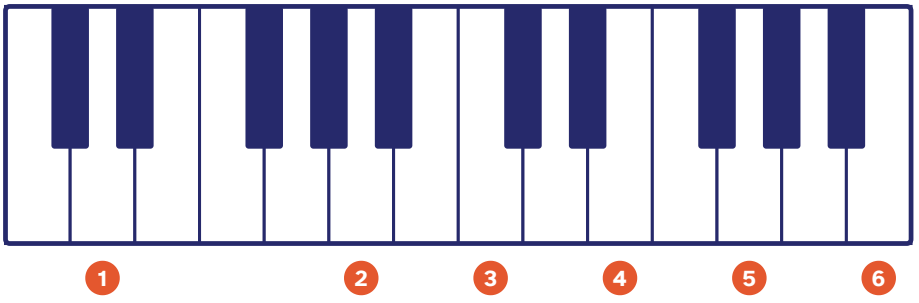


groups of two ☐ groups of three ☐

2 Name the keys

★☆☆

Find the group, then its first key, then walk on. Write the letter name of each numbered key. The first is done.



1 D 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 ☐ 6 ☐

3 Round and round

★☆☆

Seven letters, A to G, then A again. Write the next three letters: going up on the left, going down on the right. The first is done.

GOING UP	GOING DOWN
E F G **A B C**	C B A **G F E**
F G A	B A G
A B C	D C B

BEGINNER · ROOM 3

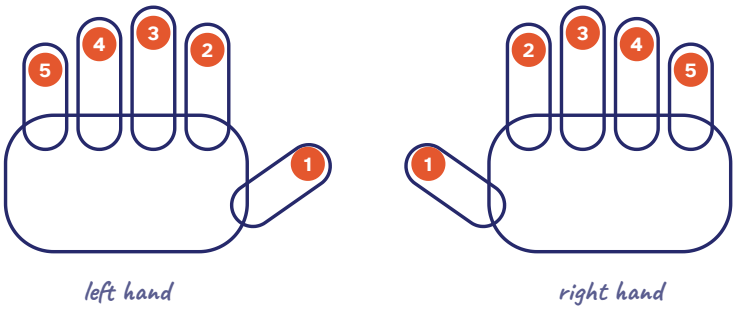
Fingering

More in the Handbook, pp. 163–164

SCAN TO LISTEN

THE SECRET

Thumbs are 1 in both hands. Choose a fingering once, write it in, keep it.



Thumbs are 1 in both hands

EXAMPLE

Which finger plays the E?

1	?	?	?	?
C	D	E	F	G

1. **Right hand:** thumb on C.
2. **One finger** for each key: C D E F G.
3. **Count up** to E: 1, 2, 3.

Finger **3**. In this position the fingers 1 2 3 4 5 play C D E F G.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

1	2	3	4	5
C	D	E	F	G

Five fingers, five keys.

Thumb on C. Play C D E F G and back, saying the finger numbers out loud.

BEGINNER · ROOM 3 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 Five-finger position ★☆☆

Right-hand thumb on C, left-hand little finger on C: write the finger for each note. The first is done.

	C	D	E	F	G
right hand	1				
left hand					

2 Which finger? ★☆☆

Right hand, thumb on C. Write the finger that plays each note. The first is done.

NOTE	E	G	D	F	C
Finger	3				

3 Play it ★☆☆

Play C D E F G up and down with each hand, saying the finger numbers. Tick a circle each day.

BEGINNER · ROOM 4

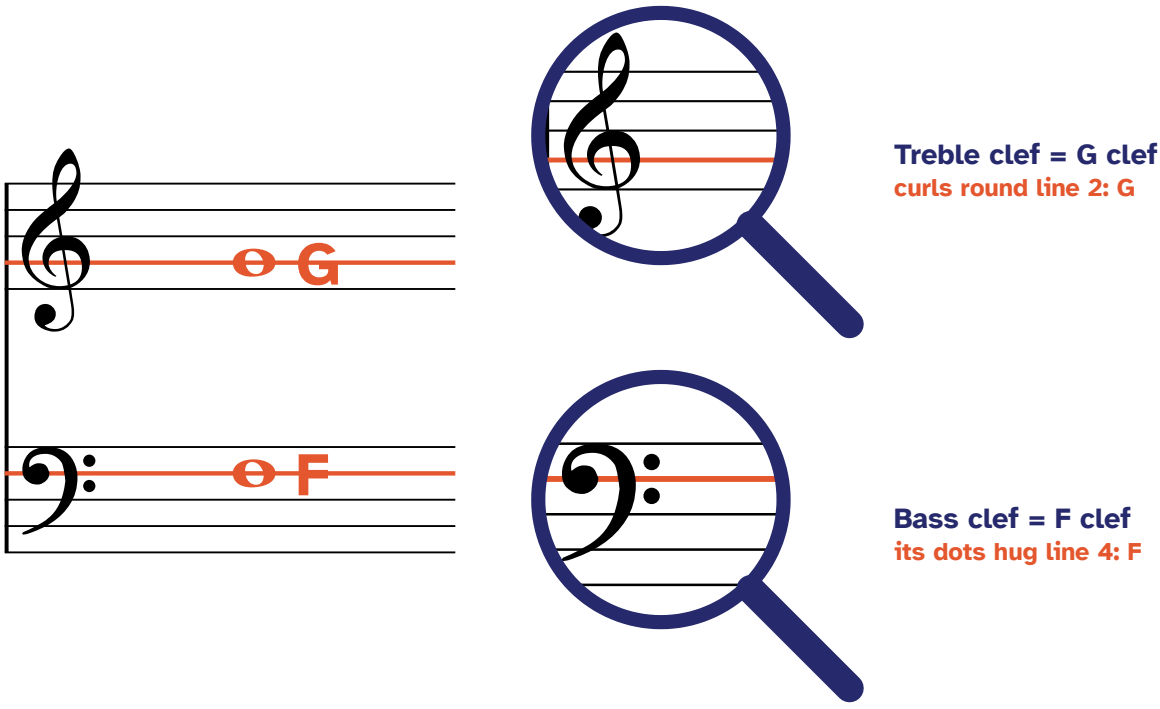
The staff and the clefs

More in the Handbook, pp. 27–28

SCAN TO LISTEN

THE SECRET

The treble clef curls round G; the bass clef's two dots hug F.



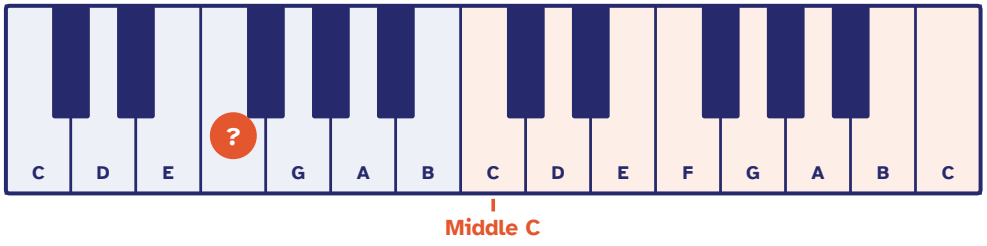
Treble clef = G clef
curls round line 2: G

Bass clef = F clef
its dots hug line 4: F

The treble clef is the G clef: it curls round G · the bass clef is the F clef: its dots hug F

EXAMPLE
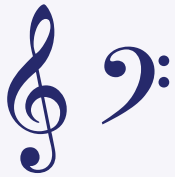
Which staff is this key written on?



1. **Find Middle C.**
2. **Is the ? to its left or right?** Left is lower: the blue half.
3. **Low keys go on the bass staff**, high keys on the treble staff.

The **?** is below Middle C, so it is written on the **bass staff**, usually for the left hand.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Draw the two clefs.

Trace a treble clef in the air, curling round line 2 (G). Then a bass clef, its dot starting on line 4 (F).

BEGINNER · ROOM 4 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 The clefs ★☆☆

Write the name of each clef and the note it marks.

CLEF	NAME	IT MARKS THE LINE FOR
		
		

2 Line or space? ★☆☆

Circle line or space, then write its number (counted from the bottom). The first is done.

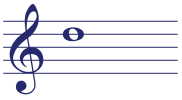


line · space
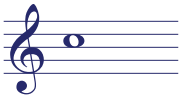
1



line · space



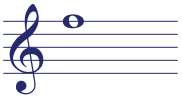
line · space



line · space



line · space



line · space

3 The grand staff ★☆☆

Complete each sentence.

Piano music joins two staves with a _____ .

The _____ staff is on top, usually for the _____ hand.

The _____ staff is below, usually for the _____ hand.

Between them, on a short line of its own, sits _____ .

BEGINNER · ROOM 5

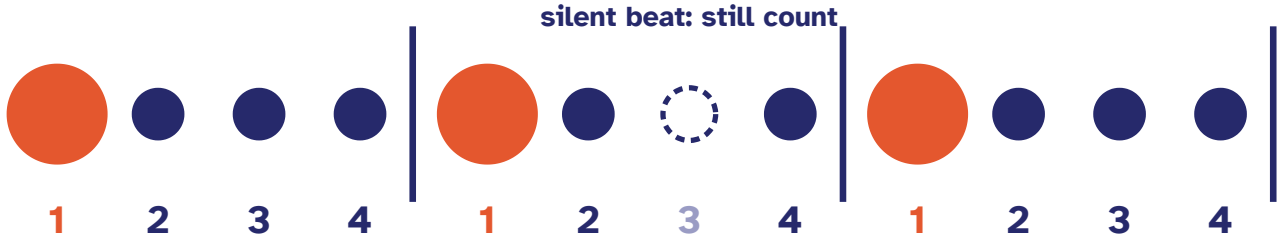
Pulse, tempo and the bar

More in the Handbook, pp. 50–52

SCAN TO LISTEN

THE SECRET

The beat is steady, like a heartbeat. Bar lines group the beats, and beat 1 of every bar is the strongest.



Beat 1 of every bar is the strongest

EXAMPLE

Feel the beat before you play



1. **Set a metronome** to 96: 96 beats a minute.
2. **Listen first:** let one bar go by, counting 1 2 3 in your head.
3. **Step in** on the next beat 1, like stepping onto a moving escalator.

The first note lands **on the beat**, not a guess.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Hand on your heart. Tap the beat.

Say “1 2 3 4” with your taps, 1 a little louder. Keep going for ten seconds without slowing down.

BEGINNER · ROOM 5 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 How many beats in each bar?

★☆☆

Count the dots between the bar lines. The first is done.



3







2 Add the bar lines

★★☆

Beat 1 is the big coral dot. Draw a bar line just before each one (the first is done).



3 Clap and count

★★☆

Set a metronome to 60. Clap on beat 1, tap your knees on 2, 3 and 4, and count aloud. Keep going for a whole minute. Tick a circle each day.

○ ○ ○ ○ ○

BEGINNER · ROOM 6

Notes: the crotchet

More in the Handbook, pp. 53–55

SCAN TO LISTEN

THE SECRET

A crotchet lasts one beat. Its rest, the crotchet rest, is one beat of silence: count it, but do not play.

4 crotchets



EXAMPLE

Count this bar



1. **Play** on each crotchet.
2. **Shh** on the rest, but keep counting.
3. **Count** 1 2 3 4 all the way through.

Play, play, shh, play: **four beats**, one each.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Clap and shh.

Clap four crotchets, counting 1 2 3 4. Clap again, but on 3 open your hands and stay silent: a rest.

BEGINNER · ROOM 6 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 How many beats?

★☆☆

Write the number of beats under each one. The first is done.



2 Play and count

★★☆

Say the counts out loud and play: a crotchet is play, a rest is shh. Write 1 2 3 4 under the bar.



3 Draw it

★★☆

Draw four crotchets, then two crotchet rests (a little lightning bolt).

BEGINNER · ROOM 7

Notes: the minim

More in the Handbook, pp. 53–55

SCAN TO LISTEN

THE SECRET

A minim lasts two beats: play on one count and hold through the next. Its rest sits on the middle line, like a hat.

2 minims



4 crotchets



EXAMPLE

How many beats in this bar?



1. **Minim:** 2 beats.
2. **Crotchet, crotchet:** 1 + 1.
3. **Add them up.**

2 + 1 + 1 = **4 beats**: a full bar.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Press and hold.

Play C as a minim: press on 1, hold through 2. Do it four times, counting out loud.

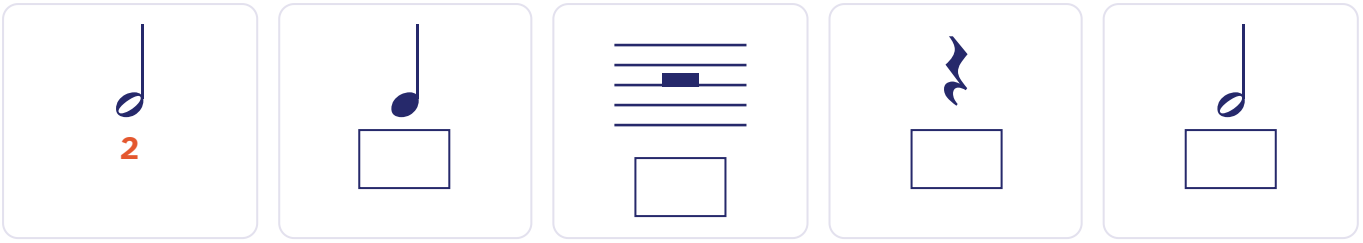
BEGINNER · ROOM 7 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 One beat or two?

★☆☆

Write 1 or 2 under each. The first is done.



2 Fill the bar

★★☆

Four beats in each bar. Write the missing note: crotchet or minim. The first is done.



minim





3 The hat

★★☆

Draw a minim rest: a block sitting on the middle line, like a hat. Then draw two minims.

BEGINNER · ROOM 8

Notes: three beats

More in the Handbook, pp. 53–55

SCAN TO LISTEN

THE SECRET

A dot after a note adds half its length again: a minim (2 beats) with a dot lasts 3 beats.



2 beats **2 + 1 = 3 beats**

The dot adds half

EXAMPLE

Which note fills a bar of three?



1. **Count** 1 2 3 for the bar.
2. **Minim:** 2. **Crotchet:** 1.
3. **Dotted minim:** 2 + 1.

The **dotted minim**: 3 beats, the whole bar.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Waltz on one note.

Play a dotted minim on C: press on 1, hold through 2 and 3. Sway on beat 1, like a waltz.

BEGINNER · ROOM 8 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 How many beats?

★☆☆

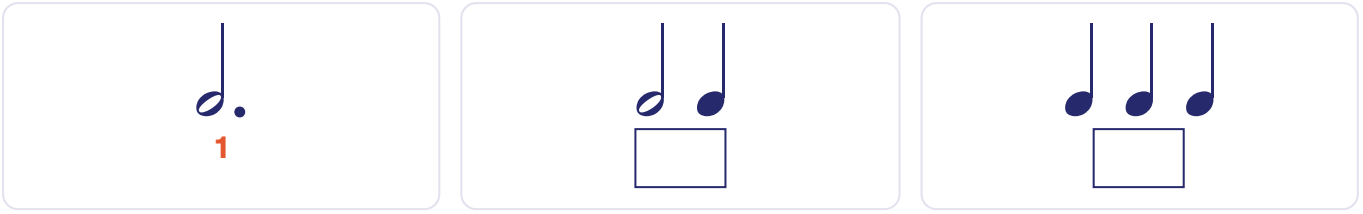
Write the number of beats. The first is done.



2 Waltz time

★★☆

Each bar has three beats. Count 1 2 3 and play each bar. Write how many notes it has. The first is done.



3 Add the dot

★★☆

Make each minim last three beats: draw the dot after it.



BEGINNER · ROOM 9

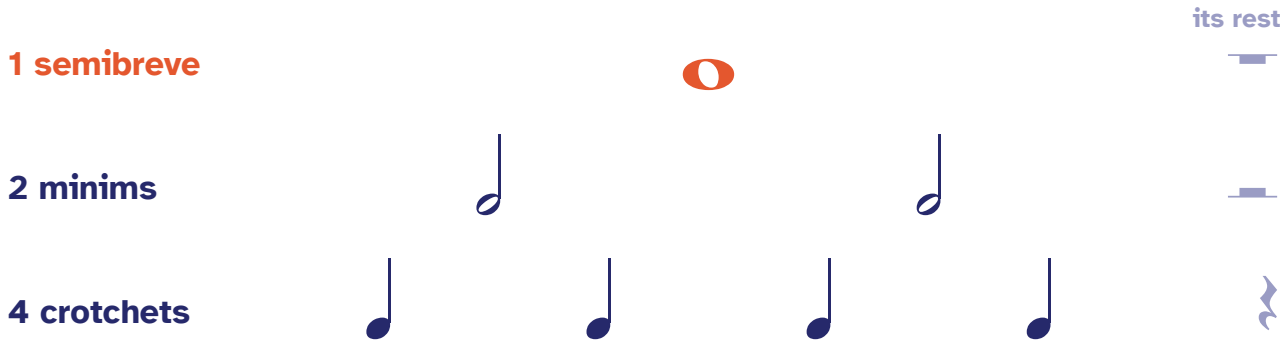
Notes: the semibreve

More in the Handbook, pp. 53–55

SCAN TO LISTEN

THE SECRET

A semibreve lasts four beats: a whole bar of four. Its rest hangs from the fourth line, like a coat.



Each note splits into two of the next

EXAMPLE

How many crotchets make a semibreve?



1. **Semibreve:** 4 beats.
2. **Crotchet:** 1 beat.
3. **Count** how many ones make four.

Four crotchets, or two minims.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Hold to the very end.

Press C and hold for 1 2 3 4. Listen until the sound has had all four beats, then lift.

BEGINNER · ROOM 9 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 Name, beats and rest

★☆☆

Fill in the table. The first row is done.

NOTE	NAME	BEATS	ITS REST
	semibreve	4	
			
			
			–

2 Coat or hat?

★☆☆

The semibreve rest hangs like a coat; the minim rest sits like a hat. Write coat or hat.

 coat			

3 Four beats

★★☆

Each bar must add up to four beats. Write the missing note.

	crotchet
	
? (one note)	

BEGINNER · ROOM 10

Loud and soft

More in the Handbook, pp. 76–78

SCAN TO LISTEN

THE SECRET

Dynamics tell you how loud to play: *p* is soft, *f* is loud. The weight of your arm makes the change, not the speed.



pp	*p*	*mp*	*mf*	*f*	*ff*
very soft	soft	half soft	half loud	loud	very loud
pianissimo	***piano***	***mezzo-piano***	***mezzo-forte***	***forte***	***fortissimo***

Six steps from a whisper to a shout

EXAMPLE

Which is louder: mp or mf?

mp* · *mf

1. **m** means *mezzo*: half.
2. **p** soft, **f** loud.
3. **Half loud** beats half soft.

mf, half loud, is louder than *mp*, half soft.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

pp* → *ff

One note, six ways.

Play Middle C *pp*, then *p*, *mp*, *mf*, *f*, *ff*: six different steps, using the weight of your arm. Then come back down.

BEGINNER · ROOM 10 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 Say it

★☆☆

Write the Italian name and what it means. The first row is done.

SIGN	NAME	MEANS
p	piano	soft
mf		
ff		
mp		
pp		
f		

2 Play it

★☆☆

Play Middle C six times: pp, p, mp, mf, f, ff. Six different steps? Tick a circle each day.

○ ○ ○ ○ ○

3 Which is louder?

★☆☆

Circle the louder sign in each pair. The first is done.

PAIR	LOUDER
p · *f*	*f*
mp · *mf*	
pp · *p*	
f · *ff*	